

## Chapter 128-4

The air fell silent for a few seconds. Wang Zhaozhao and Xiao Bai looked toward Liang Shi in unison.

After the initial awkwardness, Liang Shi also bravely admitted it.

She nodded. "Mm, I'm not."

Not only was she not straight, she was bent like a mosquito coil.<sup>1</sup>

Xiao Bai quickly said, "Sister Liang, I didn't mean it that way. It's... being gay is fine too. Sexual orientation is free now, okay? It's those trash people online who always use sexual orientation to attack others. They're shameless."

"Besides, what's wrong with liking girls? If Sister Liang liked me, I could bend immediately." Xiao Bai explained in a fluster so as not to make Liang Shi feel uncomfortable. "Getting close and cuddly with a beautiful older sister, I can do it."

Wang Zhaozhao watched with a complicated expression, practically having "Is this what you fucking call being straight?" written on her face.

Liang Shi pushed her away, ignoring her starry eyes. "I..."

Before she could finish speaking, Xiao Bai immediately said, "Oh right, except for that dog Cheng Cheng. A straight girl pretending to be gay deserves to be struck by lightning. And to turn around and bite back? That deserves five thunderbolts.<sup>2</sup> Sister Liang, your taste has always been good. No matter who you like, you can't like that kind of awful thing."

Liang Shi: "..."

She pushed away Xiao Bai, who kept moving closer, and cleared her throat. "I already have someone I like."

Xiao Bai: "?"

Wang Zhaozhao: "?"

The two asked in unison: "Who?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, wearing thick gloves as she lifted the pot lid. The rich aroma of fish soup immediately spread throughout the kitchen.

Steam surrounded Liang Shi, making her look especially ethereal.

A strand of hair fell by her ear. She used her free hand to tuck it behind her ear—a particularly beautiful scene.

Xiao Bai gulped and said righteously, "It's not Sun Chengcheng, is it?"

Wang Zhaozhao immediately dismissed the idea. "She's neither crazy nor blind. How could she like that thing?"

Liang Shi was amused by the two of them but quickly composed herself.

After a moment, she rubbed her earlobe and said, "Her name is—Xu Qingzhu."

//

When this name came out of Liang Shi's mouth again, it felt like a lifetime had passed.

And she said with certainty—I like this person.

Introducing this person to Sister Wang and Xiao Bai felt especially like bringing a girlfriend home to meet the parents, even though the girlfriend wasn't here at the moment.

And the "parents" had no idea who she was.

She couldn't pinpoint which moment her heart had been moved.

But in the days without Xu Qingzhu, she always felt listless.

Before, this kind of ordinary life with its everyday joys could give her immense satisfaction. But now she was living the life she wanted, yet felt empty because Xu Qingzhu wasn't in it.

That person had seeped into her life like water, filling her completely.

As a result, now that this person wasn't in her life, her life was a mess.

Liang Shi was already trying hard to live, but she couldn't accept a life without Xu Qingzhu.

She had never learned about such things and didn't know what liking was, or what love was.

But she thought, this must be it, right?

Missing someone to the point of tears, wanting to go back and stay by her side.

Even in days so boring she would zone out, as long as that person was in the same space as her, those would be brilliantly radiant days.

Liang Shi brought the fish soup to the table. Under the urging gazes of Sister Wang and Xiao Bai, she slowly recounted what had happened during those days.

She didn't mention those strange settings.

She said she had gone on a journey and met many people.

There was Xu Qingzhu, Zhao Xuning, Shen Hui, Zhou Yi'an, Gu Xingyue, Qi Jiao, and many, many more.

She said she had gained family members who doted on her, and someone who would watch movies with her.

They had spent many unforgettable nights together.

Liang Shi said, "Only by her side do I feel truly alive."

The days before meeting her had been flavorful enough.

But after meeting her, it was magnificent waves, rolling peaks and valleys, gentle tides.

Because the days spent with her were so, so beautiful, it made the current days seem even more boring.

"Having crossed the vast ocean, no other waters can compare; having seen the clouds of Mount Wu, no other clouds can measure up."<sup>2</sup>

Xiao Bai used this poem to summarize and elevate the moment.

As a result, Wang Zhaozhao shot her a look. "Only you would understand?"

Xiao Bai sheepishly touched the tip of her nose. "I was just moved listening to it."

Wang Zhaozhao ignored her.

After finishing her story, Liang Shi said, "Actually, I wasn't moved at first. It was later that I realized she had already become a part of my life. I kept thinking of her unconsciously. Seeing her smile would make me happy; seeing her cry would make me sad. This... is liking someone, right?"

She asked cautiously.

- 
1. Bent like a mosquito coil (彎成了蚊香): A humorous Chinese internet slang. "Bent" (彎) is slang for being gay/homosexual (as opposed to "straight"). A mosquito coil is a spiral-shaped incense used to repel mosquitoes, so being "bent like a mosquito coil" means being extremely gay—not just a little bent, but coiled around multiple times. ⇐
  2. Five thunderbolts (五雷轟頂): A traditional Chinese curse meaning to be struck by five types of thunder/lightning. It's an intensified version of "struck by lightning" (天打雷劈), expressing that someone deserves severe divine punishment for their wrongdoing. ⇐
  3. "Having crossed the vast ocean..." (曾經滄海難為水，除卻巫山不是雲): A famous line from a poem by Yuan Zhen (779-831), a Tang Dynasty poet. It means that after experiencing something truly extraordinary (like the vast ocean or the mystical clouds of Mount Wu), nothing else can compare. It's commonly used to describe a love so profound that no one else could ever measure up. The full implication is that once you've loved someone deeply, no one else will ever be enough. ⇐